

Word family: **shift / shifts / shifted / shifting / shifter / shiftless / shifty**

Base word: shift

Forms: shifts, shifted, shifting

Related forms: shifter

More independent lexical relatives: shiftless, shifty

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “If we continue treating eateries as makeshift classrooms, we will not solve the city's space problem; we will merely **shift its cost onto others**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **shift** means **to transfer a cost, burden, responsibility, or disadvantage from one person or group to another instead of removing it**.

繁體中文： **轉嫁**；把原本應由某一方承擔的成本、責任或負擔轉到另一方身上**

中文翻譯：

> “...we will merely **shift its cost onto others**.”

「.....我們只不過是把這個問題的成本**轉嫁給其他人**。」

Here:

shift the cost onto others = 問題本身沒有被解決，只是改由其他人承受其代價

1. **shift = move something from one position/place to another (位置) — 移動；挪動**

Meaning: To move someone or something physically from one place or position to another.

Practice 1

> “Could you **shift** the chair a little?”

「你可以把椅子稍微**挪一下**嗎？」

Practice 2

> “She **shifted** the boxes to the other side of the room.”

「她把箱子**移到**房間另一邊。」

****shift = 把某人 / 某物由原來的位置移到另一個位置****

Common:

* shift the furniture

* shift position

* shift something aside

* shift something forward/back

This is the central physical sense.

2. ****shift = move your own body/position slightly (身體) — 挪動；變換姿勢****

Practice 3

> “He ****shifted**** in his seat.”

「他在座位上**挪了挪身體 / 換了姿勢**。」

Practice 4

> “She ****shifted**** her weight onto her left foot.”

「她把身體重心**移到**左腳。」

****shift = 身體、重心或姿勢由一個位置轉到另一個位置****

For strict counting, this belongs under Meaning 1.

3. ****shift = change from one state, idea, method, focus, etc. to another (轉變) — 改變；轉向；轉移****

This is one of the most important abstract meanings.

Practice 5

> “The company ****shifted**** its focus toward online sales.”

「公司把重點**轉向**網上銷售。」

Practice 6

> “Public attitudes have ****shifted**** considerably.”

「公眾態度已經明顯****改變****。」

Practice 7

> “We need to ****shift**** from short-term thinking to long-term planning.”

「我們需要由短期思維****轉向****長期規劃。」

****shift = 從一種狀態、做法、重點、方向或觀點轉變到另一種****

Common:

- * shift focus
- * shift attention
- * shift priorities
- * shift strategy
- * shift direction
- * shift from A to B

This is a major core sense.

4. ****shift = transfer something to another person/place/system (轉移) — 轉移 ; 調動****

****Shift**** can mean moving work, production, resources, activity, etc. from one person, department, location, or system to another.

Practice 8

> “The company ****shifted**** production overseas.”

「公司把生產****轉移到****海外。」

Practice 9

> “Some tasks were ****shifted**** to another department.”

「部分工作被****轉交 / 轉移到****另一個部門。」

****shift = 把工作、資源、活動、功能等由一方轉到另一方****

This grows from the physical-movement sense but is highly important abstractly.

5. **shift a cost/burden/responsibility onto someone = transfer the burden (轉嫁) — 轉嫁成本 / 責任 / 負擔**

This is the **exact meaning in your passage**.

Practice 10 — Original

> “The policy would simply **shift the cost onto** other people.”

「這項做法只會把成本**轉嫁給**其他人。」

Practice 11

> “The company tried to **shift responsibility onto** its suppliers.”

「公司試圖把責任**轉嫁給**供應商。」

Practice 12

> “Higher fees may **shift the burden onto** customers.”

「較高收費可能會把負擔**轉嫁到**顧客身上。」

shift X onto someone = 沒有真正消除 X，而是令另一個人 / 群體開始承擔它

Common:

- * shift the cost onto
- * shift the burden onto
- * shift responsibility onto
- * shift blame onto

This deserves explicit treatment even though conceptually it belongs to Meaning 4.

6. **shift the blame = try to make someone else responsible (責任) — 推卸 / 轉嫁責任**

Practice 13

> “He tried to **shift the blame** onto his colleague.”

「他試圖把責任**推卸 / 轉嫁給**同事。」

Practice 14

> “There is no point **shifting blame**.”

「互相**推卸責任**沒有意義。」

This is a particularly common fixed collocation.

It belongs to the transfer-responsibility branch.

7. **a shift = change in direction, attitude, policy, pattern, etc. (名詞) — 轉變 ; 變化**

As a noun, **shift** can mean a noticeable change from one condition or pattern to another.

Practice 15

> “There has been a major **shift** in consumer behaviour.”

「消費者行為出現了重大**轉變**。」

Practice 16

> “The report describes a **shift** toward smaller households.”

「報告描述了家庭規模縮小的**趨勢轉變**。」

a shift = 從一個方向、狀態或模式轉向另一個的變化

Common:

- * major shift
- * gradual shift
- * cultural shift
- * shift in attitude
- * shift toward something

This is the noun counterpart of Meaning 3.

8. **shift = work period (工作) — 輪班 ; 班次**

A completely different major noun sense.

****Meaning:**** A scheduled period during which someone works, especially in a job operating across different hours.

Practice 17

> “She works the night ****shift****.”

「她上****夜班****。」

Practice 18

> “My ****shift**** ends at six.”

「我的****班次****六點結束。」

Common:

- * day shift
- * night shift
- * morning shift
- * evening shift
- * work a shift
- * start/end a shift

****shift = 員工被安排工作的特定時段****

This is a genuinely distinct core meaning.

9. ****shift work = 輪班工作****

Practice 19

> “Nurses often do ****shift work****.”

「護士經常需要做****輪班工作****。」

****shift work = 工作時間分成不同班次，由不同員工輪流工作的制度****

This is a major compound under Meaning 8.

10. **shift = change gear in a vehicle (汽車) — 換檔；變速**

As a verb, **shift** can mean changing from one gear to another.

Practice 20

> “He **shifted** into a lower gear.”

「他**換到**較低檔。」

Practice 21

> “The car **shifts** smoothly.”

「這部車**換檔**很順暢。」

****shift gears = 改變車輛變速箱的檔位****

Especially common in American English.

11. **shift gears = change approach/topic/activity (比喻) — 轉換方向；改變節奏**

The vehicle metaphor is also very common figuratively.

Practice 22

> “Let’s **shift gears** and discuss the next issue.”

「我們**轉換一下方向**，討論下一個問題。」

Practice 23

> “The company had to **shift gears** quickly.”

「公司不得不迅速**改變策略 / 轉換做法**。」

****shift gears = 改變思考、討論、工作或策略的方向 / 節奏****

This is a fixed figurative construction under Meaning 3.

12. **shift = gear lever / gear-changing mechanism (汽車名詞) — 排檔桿；換檔裝置**

Especially in American English, **shift** can refer to the mechanism used for changing gears.

More commonly:

- * gear shift

- * stick shift

Practice 24

> “Put the gear **shift** into reverse.”

「把**排檔**推到倒車檔。」

This is a lexicalized vehicle use.

13. **Shift** = keyboard key (電腦) — Shift 鍵 ; 換檔鍵

On a keyboard, the **Shift key** is used to type capital letters or alternate symbols.

Practice 25

> “Hold down **Shift** and press the letter.”

「按住 **Shift 鍵** , 再按字母。」

Practice 26

> “Press **Shift** to type the upper symbol.”

「按 **Shift** 輸入上方的符號。」

This is a highly established modern computing noun.

14. **shift** = move bits/data left or right (電腦 / 數碼) — 位移 ; 移位

In computing, **shift** can mean moving binary bits or data positions.

Practice 27

> “The program **shifts** the bits to the left.”

「程式把位元向左**位移**。」

Common:

- * left shift
- * right shift
- * bit shift
- * shift operator

****shift = 把數碼資料的位置按固定單位向左 / 右移動****

This is a genuine technical sense, conceptually derived from physical displacement.

15. ****shift = linguistic change in sounds/meaning (語言學) — 音變 ; 語義轉變****

In linguistics, a ****shift**** can mean a systematic change.

Examples:

- * vowel shift
- * sound shift
- * semantic shift
- * language shift

Practice 28

> “The language underwent a major vowel ****shift****.”

「這種語言經歷了一次重大的母音****音變****。」

Practice 29

> “The word has undergone a semantic ****shift****.”

「這個詞的意思發生了****語義轉變****。」

This belongs broadly to Meaning 7 but is an important domain extension.

16. ****language shift = community changes primary language (社會語言學) — 語言轉移****

A ****language shift**** occurs when a community gradually begins using another language instead of its previous primary language.

This is an established specialist compound under the general-change sense.

17. **phase shift** = change in phase (物理 / 工程) — 相位移

In physics, electronics, waves, and signal processing:

> **phase shift**

means a change in the phase relationship of a wave or signal.

繁體中文：相位移 / 相位差變化

This is a specialist compound, not a new everyday meaning.

18. **paradigm shift** = fundamental change in framework (固定術語) — 範式轉移；重大思維轉變

Practice 30

> “The technology caused a major **paradigm shift** in the industry.”

「這項科技令業界產生重大**範式轉移 / 思維模式轉變**。」

paradigm shift = 基本假設、思考框架或運作方式出現根本性改變

This belongs to the broad “major change” branch.

19. **shift** = move merchandise/get rid of something (英式非正式) — 賣掉；清走

In informal British English, **shift** can mean successfully selling or getting rid of something.

Practice 31

> “The shop is struggling to **shift** its old stock.”

「這間店很難把舊貨**賣掉 / 清走**。」

Practice 32

> “We need to **shift** these boxes before Friday.”

Depending on context:

「我們星期五前要把這些箱子**搬走 / 處理掉**。」

shift goods/stock = 把商品賣出或清走

This is a legitimate modern informal sense.

20. **shift = remove a stain/dirt (英式非正式) — 去除 ; 清掉**

Another British informal use:

Practice 33

> “This cleaner should **shift** the stain.”

「這種清潔劑應該可以把污漬**去掉**。」

shift a stain = 把難去除的污漬清除

This is established but regional and lower priority.

21. **shift = hurry/move quickly (英式非正式) — 快走 ; 趕快移動**

In commands:

> “Shift!”

can mean:

> **快走 ! / 讓開 ! / 快點移動 ! **

This is colloquial British English.

It is related to physical movement and should not inflate the core count.

22. **shift = simple loose dress (服裝名詞) — 直筒連身裙**

A **shift** or **shift dress** can mean a simple, loose-fitting dress, typically hanging fairly straight

from the shoulders.

Practice 34

> “She wore a simple black **shift**.”

「她穿了一條簡單的黑色**直筒連身裙**。」

shift = 款式簡單、較寬鬆、通常直身剪裁的連身裙

This is a genuinely distinct noun sense.

23. **shift** = loose undergarment, historical (歷史服飾) — 女式內衣 / 襯衣

Historically, **shift** also meant a loose undergarment worn by women.

This survives mainly in historical/literary contexts.

Database status: recognize but exclude from modern general core.

Related form: **shifter**

Shifter can mean something or someone that shifts.

Most commonly:

Vehicle

> gear shifter

= **排檔桿 / 換檔器**

Cycling

> bicycle shifter

= **自行車變速控制器**

This is a useful technical family noun.

Related form: **shifty**

Shifty means seeming dishonest, secretive, or untrustworthy.

Practice 35

> “He gave me a **shifty** look.”

「他看我的眼神有點**鬼鬼祟祟** / 不可信。」

Although historically related to **shift**, modern **shifty** has developed sufficiently independently that I would treat it as a lexical relative rather than a direct meaning extension.

Related form: **shiftless**

Shiftless means lacking ambition, energy, or willingness to work.

> “a shiftless person”

= **懶散、沒有進取心的人**

It is valid but relatively uncommon and often strongly negative.

Again, lexical relative rather than a core **shift** meaning.

Important distinction: **shift vs move**

move

is the broad general word.

shift

often suggests:

- * movement from one position/state to another;
- * adjustment;
- * redistribution;
- * change of focus.

> move the chair

> shift the chair slightly

****Shift**** often sounds like repositioning rather than simply travelling.

Important distinction: ****shift vs change****

****change****

is extremely broad.

****shift****

usually emphasizes movement ****from one state/direction/emphasis to another****.

> change your plan

> shift your focus

A shift often suggests a directional change.

Important distinction: ****shift vs transfer****

****transfer****

emphasizes moving something from one person/place/system to another.

****shift****

can mean that too, but is broader and often less formal.

> transfer money

> shift responsibility

For burdens/costs, ****shift**** is especially natural.

Important distinction: ****shift vs pass on****

In your target sense:

****shift the cost onto someone****

= transfer who bears it.

pass the cost on to someone

= make that person pay the cost, especially a customer.

They often overlap:

> businesses pass higher costs on to customers.

Important distinction: **shift vs redistribute**

redistribute

means deliberately distribute something differently across several recipients.

shift

may simply move it from A to B.

> redistribute resources

> shift costs to another group

Important distinction: **shift vs switch**

switch

often suggests replacing one option with another.

shift

often emphasizes gradual or directional movement.

> switch suppliers

> shift priorities

But they overlap considerably.

Important distinction: **shift vs alter**

alter

means modify something.

****shift****

means move its position, emphasis, state, or direction.

- > alter a design
- > shift the emphasis

Grammar note: ****shift from A to B****

- > shift from cash to digital payments
- > shift from one strategy to another

= ****由 A 轉向 B****

Grammar note: ****shift something to/onto someone****

Neutral transfer

- > shift production to another plant

Burden transfer

- > shift costs onto customers
- > shift responsibility onto staff

The preposition ****onto**** often emphasizes a burden being placed on the recipient.

Countability note

As a noun, ****shift**** is countable in its main senses:

- > a shift in attitude
- > a night shift
- > three shifts

Technical uses also:

- > a bit shift
- > a phase shift

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **shift**
 * **shifts**
 * **shifted**
 * **shifting**
 * **shifter**

More independent lexical relatives:

* **shifty**
 * **shiftless**

Important constructions/compounds:

* shift focus
 * shift responsibility
 * shift the blame
 * shift the burden
 * shift gears
 * work a shift
 * night shift
 * Shift key
 * paradigm shift
 * bit shift
 * phase shift

The key semantic network is built around:

> **movement from one position/state/holder to another**

From that develop physical relocation, conceptual change, transfer of responsibility, gear-changing, computing displacement, and linguistic/scientific shifts.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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shift — physical movement	把某人 / 某物從一個位置移到另一位置

shift — change	從一種狀態、方向、重點、觀點或方式轉向另一種	
shift — transfer	把工作、資源、活動等從一方 / 地方轉到另一方	
shift cost/burden/responsibility	把原有成本、負擔或責任轉嫁到另一方	
a shift — change	方向、態度、模式、結構等的一次轉變	
shift — work period	員工被安排工作的特定班次 / 輪班	
shift — vehicle	換檔；亦可指換檔裝置	
Shift key	電腦鍵盤上的 Shift 鍵	
shift — computing	把位元 / 資料位置向左或右移位	
shift — linguistics/science	音變、語義變化、相位等的轉移 / 變化	
shift — sell/remove, BrE informal	賣掉 / 清走商品；或清除污漬	
shift — dress	簡單寬鬆的直筒連身裙	
shifter	換檔器 / 變速控制器	
shifty	鬼祟、不可信的；已形成較獨立詞義	
shiftless	懶散、沒有進取心的；較低頻	

For your original sentence

> “...we will merely ****shift its cost onto others****.”

The exact meaning is:

****shift = 不消除這項成本，而是改變由誰承擔，把代價由原本的一方轉到其他人身上****

So:

> ****shift the cost onto others****

= ****把成本 / 代價轉嫁給其他人****

The writer's argument is:

> using restaurants as makeshift classrooms does not remove Hong Kong's lack of study space—it simply ****redistributes the burden**** to restaurant operators, staff, and diners.

For your database, I would count ****7 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****shift****:

1. ****physically move/reposition****
2. ****change state, direction, attitude, focus, strategy, etc.****
3. ****transfer something from one person/place/system to another****
4. ****noun: scheduled work period****
5. ****vehicle: change gear / gear-changing mechanism****
6. ****technical displacement/change — keyboard/computing/linguistic/scientific****
7. ****noun: loose straight dress****

I would keep ****shift costs/blame/responsibility onto someone**** as an especially important

construction under #3, treat British informal ****shift stock/stains**** as lower-priority extensions, and exclude historical clothing senses from the modern core.